# Acknowledgements

This book was only made possible because my great good fortune in passing the Union Public Service Commission's Civil Services Examination in 1981, permitted me the singular honour and privilege of working for the Government of India for close to forty years. It opened doors to worlds I never knew existed and allowed me to build memories that are reflected in this book.

I am indebted to Avatar Singh Bhasin for the vast trove of information that he has painstakingly collated on India–China relations in his five-volume compendium, which I consulted for the first two chapters of my book. The future scholars on Indian foreign policy will remain deeply in his debt. I am equally indebted to Ashley Tellis for his invaluable insights and suggestions on the two chapters (3 and 5) dealing with the nuclear issue, as well as more generally on the rest of the book. His personal involvement at a critical juncture in Indo–US relations offered me a first-hand window into the subject matter in both chapters from the American perspective. Ranjana Sengupta was also kind enough to give my manuscript a once-over before I submitted it to the publishers, and her insights have helped to make the book a more focused one.

I am deeply grateful to the editorial team at Penguin Random House India for working on this manuscript and, in particular, to Elizabeth Kuruvilla, who showed enthusiasm and encouragement every step of the way. Her suggestions were invaluable in this book taking its final form.